

THE POWER OF AN EGG

When children grow up without adequate nutrition, particularly protein-rich foods, the effects are long-term and irreversible. Malnutrition undermines physical growth, cognitive development, educational performance, and future productivity. Over time, it erodes a country's human capital, slowing development not just for years, but for decades. In countries like Sri Lanka, protein rich foods such as meat and fish are most often too expensive. Eggs offer a cost-effective and protein rich alternative to many vulnerable communities, however, in some instances, even that is an unaffordable luxury.

Ms. B. Mekala, a tea estate worker from the Lower Division of the HOPE Tea Estate in Nuwara Eliya, is a testament to this harsh reality.

“For a long time, even though I worked continuously on the estate, our income did not increase,” she says. “We were not able to give our children eggs regularly. There was no nearby shop, and only on payday could we afford it.”

Mekala's experience reflects a wider reality across Sri Lanka's estate sector — one of the country's most historically marginalized populations, marked by entrenched poverty and deep gender inequalities.

“Our children suffered from nutrition deficiencies,” she explains. “It affected their education as well.”



These challenges have been magnified by a series of overlapping crises. Climate change has disrupted agriculture through erratic rainfall, droughts, floods, and rising temperatures. Sri Lanka's rural economy, heavily dependent on natural resources, has faced consecutive shocks: COVID-19, rising global prices, an economic crisis and fuel shortages.

According to the Sri Lanka Development Update (2023 / 2024) published by the World Bank, Poverty has more than doubled from 2019 to 2022. According to the WFP Household Food Security Overview 2023 – Sri Lanka, 24 percent of households are food insecure, and as stated in the UNICEF Sri Lanka Humanitarian Situation Report (2023) 62 percent have adopted livelihood-based coping strategies just to access food — leaving them dangerously exposed to future shocks.



Women have borne the brunt of this crisis. As out-migration of males increased in search of income, women were left to manage households, care work, and livelihoods, often without access to assets, technology, finance, or decision-making power.

In response, the 'Empowering Women Smallholder Farmers through Renewable Energy-Based Agriculture Modernization Technologies' project funded by the Japanese Supplementary Budget (JSB) of the Government of Japan and implemented by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) in Sri Lanka, supported a poultry-based food and nutrition security intervention in estate communities in Nuwara Eliya, addressing vulnerability at its most fundamental level.

Importantly, the interventions, were intentionally designed to fit within the realities of estate women's lives. Recognizing that estate workers already endure long, physically demanding hours under difficult working conditions, the poultry farming support was structured to be low-maintenance and time-efficient, ensuring that improving household nutrition did not become an additional burden for women. Instead of increasing unpaid care or labour responsibilities, this helped ease household stress while delivering tangible benefits.

Mekala received chickens, a poultry coop, feed, and practical training, alongside regular follow-up, guidance, and monitoring from UNDP, allowing her to build confidence and skills without disrupting her daily work on the estate.



Equally important, the intervention was organized collectively: 100 estate workers formed a group, strengthening cooperation, peer learning, and shared responsibility. By working together, women were able to support one another, share knowledge, and manage production in a way that was both practical and sustainable.

“The technical officers come regularly, gives us advice, and supports us with the knowledge we need,”

Today, Mekala's children consume eggs regularly as part of nutritious meals — a simple change with transformative implications. What was once a payday luxury is now part of daily life.

“Now we can give our children good, nutritious food with eggs,”

The impact extends beyond individual households. Eggs collected by the group are supplied to preschools and schools, directly supporting child nutrition across the estate. Surplus eggs are sold to shops, generating additional income for families.

Through one intervention, multiple outcomes converge: improved nutrition, increased income, strengthened community bonds, and reduced vulnerability.



For the Government of Japan, human security is about protecting people from critical threats while empowering them to live with dignity and resilience. According to the 2025 peer-reviewed study 'Energy and Buildings', Sri Lankan households pay electricity tariffs that are approximately 2.5 to 3 times higher than regional averages. Sri Lanka faces significant energy affordability challenges.

Considering which it becomes vital to ensure the energy and food security of the country's most vulnerable communities.



An egg, in this context, is not small. It is fuel for learning, protection for health, and an investment in the country's future workforce.

In the hills of Nuwara Eliya, this intervention is proving that when development reaches the kitchen table, it reaches the classroom, the economy, and the nation itself. Sometimes, the most powerful development solutions are the simplest — and the most human.

In development, impact is often measured in large numbers — hectares cultivated, megawatts generated, incomes increased. Yet in Sri Lanka's estate sector, one of the most powerful development interventions can be as small — and as profound — as an egg.